No. 23-1668

UNITED STATES COURT OF APPEALS FOR THE FIRST CIRCUIT

KIMBERLY A. GRIFFIN,

Plaintiff – Appellant,

v.

MASSACHUSETTS DEPARTMENT OF REVENUE,

Defendant – Appellee.

On Appeal from the United States District Court for the District of Massachusetts

BRIEF OF APPELLEE

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STATEMENT OF THE ISSUES

1. Did the District Court err in dismissing Griffin's Complaint pursuant to Fed. R. Civ. P. 12(b)(6) for failure to state a claim upon which relief can be granted due to Griffin's failure to plead sufficient facts to establish that her religious belief or religious practice prevented her from being vaccinated?

STATEMENT OF THE CASE

On November 22, 2022, Kimberly Griffin ("Appellant" or "Griffin") filed a complaint with the United States District Court for the District of Massachusetts ("District Court") alleging that the Massachusetts Department of Revenue (the "DOR") discriminated against her on the basis of her religion (the "Complaint"). (Appx 8-12). Specifically, the Complaint alleged that the DOR discriminated against her under Title VII by denying her request for an exemption from the Commonwealth of Massachusetts' ("Commonwealth") COVID-19 vaccine requirement for executive department employees on religious grounds and by terminating her employment due to her admitted failure to comply with the Commonwealth's vaccine requirement.

On February 3, 2023, the DOR filed its Motion to Dismiss Griffin's Complaint pursuant to Fed. R. Civ. P. 12(b)(6) on the grounds that Griffin failed to plead sufficient facts to meet the required legal elements of her religious discrimination claim.

On July 20, 2023, the District Court issued an Order granting the DOR's Motion

to Dismiss Griffin's Complaint (the "Order") (Appx 43-56). In its Order, the District Court found that Griffin had failed to allege sufficient facts to establish that the Commonwealth's vaccination requirement conflicted with a sincerely held religious practice or belief. For that reason, the District Court determined that Griffin had failed to establish a prima facie case of religious discrimination under Title VII, and dismissed Griffin's Complaint.

On August 8, 2023, Griffin filed a Notice of Appeal as to the District Court's Order. For the reasons explained herein, the District Court's Order should stand in all respects.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

A. Relevant Statement of Facts Considered by the District Court

On August 19, 2021, the Commonwealth of Massachusetts adopted a mandatory COVID-19 vaccination policy for executive department employees. (Appx 44-45).[1] The policy provided for exemptions for medical or religious reasons. See Executive Order No. 595, Implementing a Requirement for COVID-19 Vaccination for the Commonwealth's Executive Department Employees. Id.[2]

[1] The documents submitted as part of the Appendix are cited to herein as "Appx #"

[2] The District Court relied on the facts alleged in the Complaint and certain documents provided by the parties, including (1) Griffin's request for an exemption (2) a follow up e-mail explaining her responses (3) the DOR's denial of her request (4) Griffin's follow-up emails requesting an opportunity for further reconsideration; and (5) Griffin's e-mail stating her objection to her termination. See *Watterson v. Page*, 987 F.2d 1, 3 (1st Cir. 1993) (Appx 44).

SUMMARY OF THE ARGUMENT

In her Complaint, Griffin alleged that the DOR discriminated against her in violation of Title VII of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 by failing to grant her request for a religious exemption from the Commonwealth's COVID-19 vaccine requirement. After receiving Griffin's request for an exemption from the vaccine requirement, the DOR engaged Griffin in an interactive dialogue. As part of the interactive dialogue the DOR asked Griffin, in writing, to expand on how a COVID-19 vaccine conflicted with her asserted sincerely held religious beliefs. Griffin failed to describe a religious belief or practice of any kind, but rather replied that:

> "My sincerely held religious belief is that I should not receive the COVID-19 vaccine. I have closely contemplated with God and have been shown that I should not receive the Covid-19 vaccine. Therefore, the Covid-19 vaccine specifically conflicts with my sincerely held religious belief."

(Appx 21-24).

ARGUMENT

I. The District Court Did Not Err In Dismissing Griffin's Action Pursuant To Fed. R. Civ. P. 12(b)(6)

A. The Applicable Standard of Review

This Court reviews the District Court's granting of a motion to dismiss under Fed. R. Civ. P. 12(b)(6) de novo. See *Hostar Marine Transp. Sys., Inc. v. United States*,

592 F.3d 202, 207 (1st Cir. 2010). The Court is "not wedded to the lower court's rationale, but, rather, may affirm its order on any independent ground made manifest by the record." *InterGen N.V. v. Grina*, 344 F.3d 134, 141 (1st Cir. 2003).

To survive a motion to dismiss under Rule 12(b)(6), a complaint must contain sufficient factual matter, accepted as true, to "state a claim to relief that is plausible on its face." *Ashcroft v. Iqbal*, 556 U.S. 662, 678 (2009) (quoting *Bell Atl. Corp. v. Twombly*, 550 U.S. 544, 570 (2007)). The Court must accept all well-pleaded facts alleged in the Complaint as true and draw all reasonable inferences in favor of the plaintiff. *Watterson v. Page*, 987 F.2d 1, 3 (1st Cir. 1993). This "does not mean, however, that a court must (or should) accept every allegation made by the complainant, no matter how conclusory or generalized." *United States v. AVX Corp.*, 962 F.2d 108, 115 (1st Cir. 1992). The Court is not obliged to "honor subjective characterizations, optimistic predictions, or problematic suppositions ...." *Id.* Moreover, "a reviewing court need not 'swallow plaintiff's invective hook, line, and sinker; bald assertions, unsupportable conclusions, periphrastic circumlocutions, and the like need not be credited.' " *Mass. Sch. of Law v. ABA*, 142 F.3d 26, 40 (1st Cir. 1998) (quoting *Aulson v. Blanchard*, 83 F.3d 1, 3 (1st Cir. 1996)).

Dismissal for failure to state a claim is appropriate when the pleadings fail to set forth "factual allegations, either direct or inferential, respecting each material element necessary to sustain recovery under some actionable legal theory." *Berner v. Delahanty*, 129 F.3d 20, 25 (1st Cir. 1997) (quotation and citation omitted). The tenet that a court

must accept as true all of the allegations contained in a complaint is inapplicable to legal conclusions. *Iqbal*, 556 U.S. at 678. Moreover, threadbare recitals of the elements of a cause of action, supported by mere conclusory statements, do not suffice. *Id.*

CONCLUSION

For the foregoing reasons, the DOR respectfully requests that this Court affirm the Order and Judgment of the District Court to dismiss Griffin's Complaint with prejudice.

Respectfully submitted,

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January 2, 2024

CERTIFICATE OF COMPLIANCE

1. This document complies with the type-volume limit of Fed. R. App. P. 32(a)(7)(B) because, excluding the parts of the document exempted by Fed. R. App. P. 32(f):

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/s/ Jeffrey T. Collins
Attorney for Defendant – Appellee
Massachusetts Department of Revenue
Dated: January 2, 2024

CERTIFICATE OF SERVICE

I hereby certify that on January 2, 2024, I electronically filed the foregoing with the Clerk of the Court for the United States Court of Appeals for the First Circuit by using the appellate CM/ECF system, which will send notification of such filing to all counsel of record.

/s/ Jeffrey T. Collins
Attorney for Defendant – Appellee
Massachusetts Department of Revenue
Dated: January 2, 2024